

PLAYBOOK 03 · EMAIL & LIFECYCLE

Email Marketing Engine at 138K+ Scale

Turning a large database into an engaged, measurable lifecycle system for MNF.ai.

Platform: MNF.ai

Scope: Lifecycle Email · Deliverability · Automation · Audience Segmentation · Engagement

138K+

AUDIENCE PROFILES

~64%

AVERAGE OPEN RATE

~12%

AVERAGE CTR

<2%

BOUNCE RATE

Business Context & Deliverability Challenge

MNF.ai had a combined database of 138K+ profiles, consisting of two fundamentally different groups: registered filmmakers and cold prospects.

THE DELIVERABILITY SCALING CHALLENGE

Scaling communication across both groups created a central challenge: How do you increase email reach and engagement without damaging relevance, deliverability or sender reputation?

The Core Problem: 13K+ Registered Users (existing users with a relationship with the product) vs. **125K+ Cold Prospects** (prospects requiring education, relevance and trust before stronger conversion messaging).

Strategic Objectives

- Decouple fundamentally different audience groups.
- Establish stronger domain and sender trust.
- Improve list hygiene and reduce invalid addresses.
- Build automated lifecycle nurture journeys.
- Maintain engagement while scaling communication.
- Measure email performance beyond simple delivery.
- Protect sender reputation while increasing outreach volume.

STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE

"The bigger the database, the more important segmentation and deliverability become."

Audience & Lifecycle Architecture

SEGMENT → AUTHENTICATE → AUTOMATE → MEASURE → OPTIMISE

The email system was structured around audience intent and lifecycle stage, rather than treating the entire 138K+ database as a single audience.

01 — REGISTERED USERS

13K+ profiles

Dedicated communication paths around:

- Onboarding
- Product activation
- Feature updates
- Workshops
- Tutorials

02 — COLD PROSPECTS

125K+ profiles

Problem-centric nurture designed to build familiarity and trust before stronger sales messaging.

03 — LIST VERIFICATION

Used Bouncify to identify and remove invalid/disposable addresses before deployment.

WHY THIS MATTERED

Blending users and cold prospects into one communication stream could dilute message relevance and negatively affect sender reputation.

Different intent → Different journey → Different message.

Deliverability Foundation (Deliverability Before Scale)

Before increasing communication volume, the system needed a technical foundation capable of supporting sender reputation and inbox placement.

01 — SPF

Established authorised sending infrastructure and strengthened domain-level trust.

02 — DKIM

Implemented cryptographic email signing to authenticate outgoing messages.

03 — DMARC

Configured domain alignment and monitoring to strengthen authentication and protect the sending domain.

04 — SENDER WARM-UP

Used automated warm-up processes to gradually establish sender reputation before scaling outreach.

05 — LIST HYGIENE

Integrated pre-send verification to remove invalid and disposable addresses.

DELIVERABILITY OPERATING MODEL

Authenticate → Verify → Warm → Send → Monitor

KEY PRINCIPLE

“Deliverability is not a post-send problem. It is part of the email system itself.”

Lifecycle Automation & Message Strategy

From Campaigns to Automated Journeys: The email system evolved beyond isolated broadcasts into lifecycle-oriented communication paths.

LIFECYCLE FLOW

01 — ONBOARDING: Introduce the product and help newly registered users understand the platform.



02 — ACTIVATION: Move users toward meaningful product engagement.



03 — NURTURE: Educate prospects around their problems and relevant product value.



04 — RE-ENGAGEMENT: Reconnect with audiences showing declining engagement or inactivity.



05 — RETENTION: Continue relevant communication with existing users.

DELIVERY STACK & ORCHESTRATION

Amazon SES · Brevo · Mailchimp: Used across scalable transactional and bulk email infrastructure.

Kestra · Google Sheets: Used for event-triggered routing and keeping lead/user journey steps synchronised.

COPY FRAMEWORK (PROBLEM → AGITATE → SOLUTION)

PAS copy was used to frame screenwriter pain points around relevant problems rather than leading with hard-sell messaging.

Measurement & Optimisation (Email Performance & Decision Framework)

Email performance was treated as a system of signals rather than a single open-rate metric.

~64%

AVERAGE OPEN RATE

~12%

AVERAGE CTR

<2%

BOUNCE RATE

Optimisation Decision Log

Signal Observed	Decision Taken	Strategic Rationale
Blended audience cohorts	Separated registered users from cold prospects	Improved message relevance and protected sender reputation
Cold-sending risk	Hardened SPF/DKIM/DMARC and introduced warm-ups	Established technical trust before scaling volume
Risky addresses / bounces	Added pre-send Bouncify verification	Removed invalid and disposable addresses
Corporate-style copy drop-off	Shifted toward minimalist plain-text PAS messaging	Improved engagement and stronger click response.

THE OPERATING QUESTION

“What is the signal telling me, and what change should that signal trigger?”

Directly connects with the broader hypothesis-driven approach used across the acquisition and lifecycle playbooks.

Results & Lifecycle Impact

Measurable lifecycle performance across the 138K+ email database at MNF.ai.

DATABASE SCALE

138K+

AUDIENCE PROFILES

13K+

REGISTERED USERS

125K+

COLD PROSPECTS

LIFECYCLE ENGAGEMENT

~64%

AVERAGE OPEN RATE

~12%

AVERAGE CTR

<2%

BOUNCE RATE

WHAT THE SYSTEM ACHIEVED

The email infrastructure supported communication across two distinct audience cohorts while maintaining measurable engagement and keeping bounce rates below 2%.

The outcome was not simply a large sending database. It was a more structured system built around:

Audience Separation → Deliverability → Automation → Engagement → Optimisation

KEY TAKEAWAY

At scale, email performance depends on the system around the message — not just the message itself.

My Email & Lifecycle Operating System

- 01 — **SEGMENT:** Separate audiences based on lifecycle stage, relationship and intent.
- 02 — **AUTHENTICATE:** Establish SPF, DKIM and DMARC before scaling communication.
- 03 — **VERIFY:** Maintain list hygiene and remove invalid addresses before sending.
- 04 — **AUTOMATE:** Build lifecycle journeys around onboarding, activation, nurture, re-engagement and retention.
- 05 — **MESSAGE:** Match communication and copy to audience context and user problems.
- 06 — **MEASURE:** Monitor delivery, engagement and downstream journey signals.
- 07 — **OPTIMISE:** Use observed performance signals to refine segmentation, deliverability, messaging and journey design.

What This Playbook Demonstrates

Lifecycle Marketing · Email Automation · Audience Segmentation · Deliverability · SPF · DKIM · DMARC · List Hygiene · Email Nurturing · PAS Copywriting · Workflow Automation · Engagement Measurement · Performance Optimisation · Large-Scale Database Management

PORTFOLIO SCOPE

Performance figures and campaign results from my work at MNF.ai are based on available platform records. Audience and engagement figures shown here represent the available records for the email marketing system. Figures are rounded/ approximate based on available data.